



ON THE WRITE LINE

Sunil Gavaskar



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IT IS SO, SO REFRESHING TO SEE TRULY MEMORABLE MOMENTS CELEBRATED WITH HUMILITY

Heroes also should be aware that their actions will be **emulated** by their young, impressionable followers.

The last Major of the world of tennis saw two winners who celebrated their wins without any of the theatrics that seem to be such an integral part of modern sport. When Elena Rybakina beat Aryna Sabalenka, she just closed her fist, gave a dimpled smile and turned to her coach and support staff to acknowledge and thank them. When Alexander Zverev won the final point, he wasn't even aware that he had won the title. He also just smiled and rushed towards the net to greet his opponent, Ben Shelton. It was so, so refreshing to see truly memorable moments celebrated with humility, without trying to rub the vanquished opponent's nose in the dust as we see so often in sports today.

Imagine if Sabalenka and Shelton had won. Sabalenka, who screams after every point she wins while making loud grunting noises during the point, would have had what can only be called a TV-friendly celebration. Shelton, who also yells after every point he wins, would have yelled the whole arena down if he had won. Of course, winning titles, especially Majors, is extraordinarily special and must be celebrated. But it would be wonderful if the defeated opponent could be spared the histrionics that are seen even as he sits in the chair.

A few years back, Shelton was making waves with his game and perhaps even more so with his telephone-answering celebration

after every other point. Then he played Novak Djokovic, who simply blew him off the court and started to mimic Shelton's telephone-answering celebration. The Serb was pulled up by the media for mocking a young opponent. So, when Shelton was doing that during his earlier matches, he wasn't mocking his opponents? These double standards weren't surprising as the winner of the most Majors in tennis has never quite enjoyed the universal popularity that his other two great rivals, Roger Federer and Rafa Nadal, did.

That is usually, not always, the way the fandom responds when their hero is being usurped by another emerging star. They try to find faults with the new star and ask questions about him to show that their hero is still the best. While this is understandable to an extent in an individual sport, it is not at all healthy in a team sport, especially when the country's team is playing. In trying to show that your hero is better, the other star gets run down and, in doing so, the team suffers. By all means, wish the best for your hero, but don't run the other star in the team down when the country is playing.

Heroes also should be aware that their actions will be emulated by their young, impressionable followers. Today's era is all about putting everything out there. That